

7, Who Could Emerge Victorious from The Great Expansion?

There were many ethnic groups involved in the historical event of **The Great Expansion**; even for those who entered the same large region speaking the same Indo-European languages, they did not necessarily identify with one another.

In China, even though the early stages of the Great Expansion did not slip from the grasp of the Zhou royal court, by the Eastern Zhou Dynasty, the various vassal states were compelled to fight entirely for themselves.

In the grand progression of history, although the emergence of a certain trend or mutation possesses inevitability, the groups or individuals possessing the conditions to actualize it are never limited to just one. *Who* ultimately claims the crowning glory is a profound test of the human agency (主观能动性) and comprehensive capabilities of heroic figures—though, naturally, the luck of the era (时运) is also indispensable.

Today, when we observe the very first batch of empires that arose following the Great Expansion, **their birthplaces were uniformly situated on the peripheries of civilization!**

The Qin people (秦人) who unified China were positioned on the western fringes during the Western Zhou period. *(The term used here, Xichui [西垂], constitutes a brilliant historical pun: it refers both to the specific location of Western Qianqiu [西犬丘] and the western frontier of the Huaxia states).* They later annexed the ancestral lands of the Zhou, expanded southward to conquer the Hanzhong (汉中) and Bashu (巴蜀) regions, and finally marched east to subjugate all other vassal states.

The Kingdom of Magadha (摩揭陀国) that unified India was located on the extreme eastern edge of the Indian Mahajanapadas. Considering that the Aryans entered India from the northwest, this was precisely the eastern frontier of the Indo-Aryan states. In the mid-6th century BC, Magadha annexed the Kingdom of Anga (鸯伽国) further to its east. At this point, the Magadhans had clearly secured a supreme geopolitical advantage identical to that of the Qin! Under the rule of several subsequent dynasties, it expanded relentlessly, ultimately ballooning into a massive empire during the Maurya Empire (孔雀王朝).

Persia (波斯) and Media (米底) require little elaboration; these two regimes were situated on the absolute margins of the traditionally defined Near Eastern civilization (up until 600 BC).

Macedon (马其顿) was relegated to the northern periphery among the various Greek city-states, even deemed "excessively barbaric" by some southern Greek states.

The waters facing the city of Rome were those of the Western Mediterranean. Let alone comparing it to the traditional city-states of the Eastern Mediterranean, Rome was positioned even further away from the Eastern Mediterranean civilizational center than remote colonial city-states like Carthage (迦太基) and Syracuse (叙拉古)!

In a certain sense, this breathtaking consistency laterally reflects the quintessential characteristics of the era of the Great Expansion. Being situated too close to the center of struggle only resulted in the pointless hemorrhaging of strength with meager returns. It dragged regimes into a quagmire of useless diplomatic entanglements, stripping them of the ability to adopt flexible geopolitical stances.

Conversely, peripheral regions were not only exempted from these tribulations and perils, but they could also—without attracting excessive attention—annex far more backward, minuscule states and tribes deemed "barbarians" (*which, in a sense, was merely a continuation of the Great Expansion itself*). This allowed them to massively expand their territories, surge their populations, and ultimately secure an overwhelming superiority in national power.

We might as well imagine: In an era where expansion had ceased and the frontiers of civilization had remained permanently fixed, could wars of unification possibly have concluded in the exact same paradigm that established the first batch of **classical empires**? I'm afraid that would be impossible! Under *those* conditions, the ultimate victor might not necessarily originate from the absolute core of civilization, but they certainly could not be located too far from it either.

The core region of a civilization dictates highly developed socio-economics, the most prosperous commercial activities, and control over critical transportation bottlenecks. Furthermore, it represents orthodox legitimacy and the "righteous cause" (大义名分); it is the ultimate military prize. Hence, ancient China had the idiom "Chasing the deer in Zhongyuan" (逐鹿中原 / vying for supremacy in the Central Plains).

This is even more quintessentially demonstrated in a closed island nation like Japan: Samurai Daimyo (武士大名) stationed too far from the Kinki region (近畿地区) obviously possessed zero chance of ever sitting on the throne of the *Tenkabito* (天下人 / Ruler of the Realm). Both the Oda (织田) and Toyotomi (丰臣) regimes had to base themselves within the Kinai (畿内) to complete the unification of Japan.

Therefore, I believe the actions of the Holy Roman Emperors during the High Middle Ages (中世纪盛期) were mind-bogglingly unwise! In this era of mass land reclamation and demographic explosions (*relative to agricultural societies, of course; it cannot be compared to the post-Industrial Revolution era*), the Germans failed to fix their gaze upon the East! Instead, they marched into Italy time and time again. Not only did this drain unfathomable amounts of time, manpower, and treasury, but it ultimately yielded absolutely nothing.

History amply demonstrates that even when the Holy Roman Emperors remained utterly inactive, the autonomous actions of minor border lords and knightly orders in eastern Germany managed to secure colossal territories for the German people by the early modern period—the renowned *Ostsiedlung* (东方殖民 / Eastward Expansion)! Later on, the two most paramount German states, Prussia and Austria, were both the direct beneficiaries of this eastward expansion (*Prussia, in particular, was built entirely upon the foundation of this expansion*).

Today, it is completely impossible to imagine: if the Holy Roman Emperors of that era had been even slightly more rational, balancing the energy invested in Italian affairs with Eastern affairs, just how monumental an achievement the Germans could have secured in Europe! And how on earth would the French have coped? But I digress (话扯远了).

7, 谁能在大扩张运动中脱颖而出

参与大扩张这一历史事件的族群并不少, 即使是同样操着印欧语进入同一个大区域的族群, 他们也未必相互认同。在中国, 即使大扩张在最初没有脱离周王室的掌控, 但是从东周开始各个诸侯国也不得不各自为战。在历史进程中, 虽然某个趋势或者变化的产生具有必然性, 但是有条件去实现这一点的团体或者个人未必只有一个, 究竟谁能立下首功那就是十分考验英雄人物们主观能动性和综合能力的时刻了, 不过时运也是缺不了的。今天我们看到的大扩张之后兴起的第一批帝国, 其龙兴之地无不在文明的

边陲。统一中国的秦人在西周时期便立于中国的西垂（这里恰好是双关语，既指西犬丘这个地方，又指当时诸夏的西部边境），后来全据周人故地，又向南兼并汉中及巴蜀地区，最终向东征服了其他诸侯国。统一印度的摩羯陀国（Magadha）在印度列国中非常靠东，考虑到雅利安人是从西北方向进入的印度，这里恰好是印度雅利安国家的东部边境。摩羯陀国在公元前六世纪中叶便吞并了更东方的鸯伽国

（Anga），至此摩羯陀人显然取得了与秦人相当的优越地缘位置，再接下来几个王朝统治下不断扩张，最终在孔雀王朝时期膨胀成为一个大帝国。波斯和米底自不必说，这两个政权处于近东文明传统意义上（到公元前600年为止）的边缘。马其顿在各个希腊城邦中处于北部边缘，甚至被南部的一些希腊城邦认为太过野蛮。罗马城所面向的水域是西地中海，这不要说跟东地中海的传统城邦相比，就是与迦太基、叙拉古这样比较偏远的殖民城邦来说都还更偏离东地中海的文明中心。

这种一致性某种意义上也从侧面反映了大扩张时代的特征，太过靠近斗争中心只会平白损失力量而少有收益，牵扯无用的外交关系而无法采取灵活的立场，而边陲地区不但免于这些忧患和危险，还可以在避免遭到过多关注的情况下吞并更加落后的，被视为蛮夷的小国家和部落（某种意义上说是大扩张的一种继续），使得自身的领土扩大，人口增加最终令国力获得优势。我们不妨想象一下，如果在一个不是扩张的，反倒是文明边境长期固定的年代，统一战争还可能以第一批古典帝国建立的那种模式结束吗？这恐怕就不能了，在这种条件下，胜利者不说一定来源于文明核心地区，至少也不能离核心太远。文明的核心地区意味着社会经济发达，商业活动最繁荣，扼守交通要冲，并且还代表着大义名分和正统性，是兵家必争之地。因此中国古有逐鹿中原之说，在日本这样封闭的岛国就更典型，太远离近畿地区的武士大名显然没有机会坐上“天下人”的宝座，织田政权和丰臣政权也是立足畿内完成了日本的统一。

因此我认为神圣罗马帝国皇帝在中世纪盛期的行动实在不明智，在这个土地开发和人口激增的年代（当然是相对农业社会来说，不可能跟工业革命之后比），德国人不把目光放向东方，反倒一次又一次跑到意大利去，耗时耗力耗财不说，最后也落得一场空。历史表明，哪怕神圣罗马帝国皇帝无所作为，单单是德国东部的边境小诸侯和骑士团的自主行动，到近代的时候就已经为德国人取得了庞大的领土

（Ostsiedlung），后来最重要的两个国家普鲁士和奥地利都受益于东扩（尤其是普鲁士就建立在东扩的基础上）。现在已经完全难以想象如果当年的神圣罗马帝国皇帝能够稍微理智一些，平衡在意大利事务和东方事务上投入的精力，德国人在欧洲究竟能取得多大的成就，法国人又能怎么应对呢。话扯远了。